INDIA PAKISTAN BALANCE OF FIREPOWER

	INDIA	PAKISTAN
DEFENCE BUDGET (2025-26)	$79 BILLION	$7.6 BILLION
ARMY MANPOWER	1,200 (in '000)	550 (in '000)
TANKS	4,200	2,627
AIR FORCE MANPOWER	150+ (in '000)	70+ (in '000)
FIGHTER JETS	606	387
ATTACK HELICOPTERS	80	57
NAVY MANPOWER	100+ (in '000)	20+ (in '000)
AIRCRAFT CARRIERS	2	0
SUBMARINES	20	8
DESTROYERS	11	0
FRIGATES	12	12
NAVAL FIGHTER JETS	41	0

Source: Global Firepower 2025 World Military Strength Rankings

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Retribution, like justice, must not only be delivered but also seen to be delivered. The Indian Army learned this lesson the hard way in 2019, when it offered only limited photographic evidence of its air strikes on terror camps in Balakot in Pakistan, launched in response to the Pulwama attack. Pakistan denied any damage, and international scepticism about the operation's success persisted. Six years later, on May 7, the Indian armed forces ensured there was no such ambiguity. In a bold response to the April 22 Pahalgam carnage, they struck nine terror installations across Pakistan and released vivid video and photographic proof of what the operation accomplished.

Operation Sindoor, as the strike was branded, was as much a military retaliation as a symbolic gesture, evident in its name and logo—vermillion powder, a marker of a married woman's status in the Hindu tradition, spilling from the 'o's in 'sindoor'. It was a poignant reference to the women who were widowed when terrorists ruthlessly gunned down 26 innocent men in the Baisaran meadow of Pahalgam. India was avenging their loss, as it were. The Modi government further reinforced the Nari Shakti (women's empowerment) narrative when it got two women officers from the armed forces to brief the press on the operation.

With Operation Sindoor, the Modi government has delivered India's most forceful military message to Pakistan in 25 years—that it has had enough of Pakistan's terror shenanigans and from now on was willing to execute a no-holds-barred retaliation. As Lt Gen. Deependra Singh Hooda (retd), then Northern Army commander who oversaw the 2016 Uri surgical strikes, put it, "If limited strikes that only neutralise foot soldiers are not enough to deter terrorism, India is now willing to target the core terrorist leadership—even deep inside Punjab. With the military-jihadi complex nearby, these strikes raise the stakes far beyond Balakot or Uri, forcing Pakistan to consider whether it's ready to go to war over its terror sanctuaries." Of the nine Pakistani terror establishments Indian armed forces struck, five were in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and four in the politically sensitive and powerful province of Punjab. It was, in fact, the first Indian air strike on Punjab since the 1971 war, and the high-value targets included the Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) headquarters in Bahawalpur and the Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) base in Muridke, near Lahore.

However, keeping in mind international concerns, India's foreign secretary Vikram Misri made it clear at a press briefing that India was not looking to go up the escalation ladder. "These actions were measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible," he said. India also clarified that it had not struck any Pakistani military infrastructure. Its military response came after it had already imposed other costs on Pakistan just a day after the Pahalgam terror attack, among them the suspension of the 65-year-old Indus Waters Treaty that lays down mutually agreed guidelines on sharing the waters of the six rivers feeding the Indus basin. Pakistan immediately declared it an act of war since two of its most